Lot Thirty-Seven

2026-11-09 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 639 词 · 5 段

短文

The vans came up the steep lane before seven, because the whole stock of the Ashfield house had to be unloaded before the viewing. Nell had spent two days packing the smaller things into crates and labelling every lid in her thin black hand. A brass bucket, a riding whip with a cracked handle, and the plaster limb of a saint stood on the long table that would occupy the room until Friday. The vans themselves annoyed her, since the fleet belonged to a man who charged by the hour. A fresh scratch ran across the veneer of the walnut chest, and she wrote it down on the sheet. Her father had made an appointment with a collector at nine, and she still had forty lots to describe.

At nine the collector arrived with an attorney from the county town and a banker who had bought three lots by telephone the previous spring. The paper they put on Nell's desk described the transfer of the whole collection, but the signatures sat in the wrong sequence, and the attorney admitted that the document was legally invalid until the executor signed again. She had expected something of the kind, because the Ashfield family had been arguing about that signature for two years, and no one had bothered to tell the auction house. Nell acknowledged the problem without raising her voice and offered an independent valuation instead. The banker studied her over the rim of his glasses, and his gaze stayed hostile for a long, silent moment.

Bidding began at eleven with a rapidity that Nell had not seen all season, since four telephone lines and the front row were all pushing the same oak dresser. The online bidders lagged a full second behind the room, which turned each increase into an argument between clerk and screen. One old man made a display of folding his catalogue and standing up, but he sat down again when the price passed nine hundred. Trade had flourished in the county that year, and the totals were remarkable for a Tuesday. Astonishment gave way to confusion when lot thirty-one arrived without a ticket, and an awkward silence followed while three people searched the same shelf. Nell could not restrain a laugh, and the dynamic of the room changed at once.

Lot thirty-seven was the walnut chest, the one with the scratch, and the auctioneer's narration had barely reached the second sentence when the attorney stood up again. He proposed that the chest be withdrawn, because its papers had traveled with the wrong estate, and he asked the room to participate in a short delay. Nell had to coordinate two telephone lines, a signed form and a boy carrying chairs, and she combined the chest with the plain table behind it so that nothing went unsold. The obstacle was not the money but the hour, and her persistence wore him down. It was a courageous decision for a girl of twenty-three, and the completion of the sale felt almost quiet. Manners dictated that she thank everyone twice.

The sale entered the historical record as the longest Tuesday in the firm's memory, and Nell wrote the total with a hand that had stopped shaking. A formation of crates grew by the door, waist high, until the last of the fleet pulled away down the lane. To some extent she had enjoyed the afternoon, though she would not have told her father. The disappearance of the plaster saint troubled her most, since nobody could name the buyer, and the driver had loaded it sideways under a tarpaulin. She ate a slice of cake with a paperback open on her knee, and by six the quarrel with the banker had begun to heal. A pedestrian stopped at the window, and one of her peers waved him in.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

The vans came **up the steep lane** before seven, because the whole stock of the Ashfield house had to be unloaded before the viewing. Nell had spent two days **packing the smaller things into crates** and labelling every lid in her thin black hand. A brass bucket, a riding whip with a cracked handle, and the plaster limb of a saint stood on the long table that would occupy the room until Friday. The vans themselves annoyed her, since the fleet belonged to a man who charged by the hour. A fresh scratch ran across the veneer of the walnut chest, and she wrote it down on the sheet. Her father had **made an appointment with** a collector at nine, and she still had forty lots to describe.

> **up the steep lane** 沿着那条陡坡小巷往上 steep 只形容坡度本身（steep slope / steep lane / steep stairs）；说价格、涨跌幅的“急剧”要用 sharp 或 sudden，两者不能互换
> **packing the smaller things into crates** 把较小的东西装箱 pack A into B 是“把 A 装进 B”，主语是人；若主语是物品自己，只能用 be packed in，不能说 the things packed into crates
> **made an appointment with** 与某人约好见面 动词固定用 make 或 have（make an appointment with sb），不用 take；take up an appointment 是“就任某职”，意思完全不同

At nine the collector arrived with an attorney from the county town and a banker who had bought three lots by telephone the previous spring. The paper they put on Nell's desk described **the transfer of the whole collection**, but the signatures sat **in the wrong sequence**, and the attorney admitted that the document was legally invalid until the executor signed again. She had expected something of the kind, because the Ashfield family had been arguing about that signature for two years, and no one had bothered to tell the auction house. Nell acknowledged the problem without raising her voice and offered **an independent valuation** instead. The banker studied her over the rim of his glasses, and his gaze stayed hostile for a long, silent moment.

> **the transfer of the whole collection** 整批藏品的移交 transfer 作名词时后面接 of，指被转移的对象；transfer to 才接接收方，如 transfer of the collection to the museum
> **in the wrong sequence** 顺序排错 在 wrong / right / correct 前用介词 in，指排列次序；说时间先后则用 in order，两者常被混用
> **an independent valuation** 独立估价 independent 在此指“不受买卖双方影响的第三方”，修饰 valuation、audit、advice 时都是这个含义，不是“独立的个体”

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> **with a rapidity that** 以……那样的速度 rapidity 多用于书面语，常搭 with rapidity 或 with a rapidity that…；口语里更常说 quickly 或 at speed
>
> **lagged a full second behind** 整整落后一秒 lag behind 是固定搭配，behind 后接被落下的对象；lag 也可作名词，如 a lag of two days，但作动词时不能省 behind
>
> **made a display of** 故意做出……的样子 make a display of sth 含贬义，指炫耀或做给人看；中性地说“展示”应用 show 或 display sth 本身

Lot thirty-seven was the walnut chest, the one with the scratch, and the auctioneer's narration had barely reached the second sentence when the attorney stood up again. He **proposed that the chest be withdrawn**, because its papers had traveled with the wrong estate, and he asked the room to participate in a short delay. Nell had to **coordinate two telephone lines**, a signed form and a boy carrying chairs, and she combined the chest with the plain table behind it so that nothing went unsold. The obstacle was not the money but the hour, and her persistence **wore him down**. It was a courageous decision for a girl of twenty-three, and the completion of the sale felt almost quiet. Manners dictated that she thank everyone twice.

> **proposed that the chest be withdrawn** 提议把柜子撤下 propose that 后接虚拟语气，动词用原形 be，不加 is 或 was；withdraw 在此是“撤回拍品”，被动 be withdrawn
>
> **coordinate two telephone lines** 协调两部电话 coordinate 直接接被协调的对象，不加 with；要说明“与谁协调”才用 coordinate sth with sb
>
> **wore him down** 把他磨到让步 wear sb down 指靠持久消耗使对方屈服，宾语放中间；wear down 也可用于物，如 tyres worn down by use

The sale **entered the historical record** as the longest Tuesday in the firm's memory, and Nell wrote the total with a hand that had stopped shaking. A formation of crates grew by the door, waist high, until the last of the fleet pulled away down the lane. **To some extent** she had enjoyed the afternoon, though she would not have told her father. The disappearance of the plaster saint troubled her most, since nobody could name the buyer, and the driver had loaded it sideways under a tarpaulin. She ate a slice of cake with a paperback open on her knee, and by six the quarrel with the banker had **begun to heal**. A pedestrian stopped at the window, and one of her peers waved him in.

> **entered the historical record** 被载入历史记录 historical 指“与历史有关的、作为史料留存”，historic 才指“有历史意义的”；此处是前者，不能说 historic record
> **To some extent** 在某种程度上 固定搭配，extent 前用 to；口语中常置于句首或句尾，比 to a certain degree 更自然
> **begun to heal** 开始弥合 heal 用于伤口，也用于关系、争执等抽象对象，此时不接 up（heal up 只指伤口长好）

译文

七点前，货车沿着那条陡坡小巷开上来，因为阿什菲尔德老宅的全部存货都得在预展之前卸完。内尔花了两天把较小的东西装箱，用她那手细瘦的黑字在每块箱盖上贴了标签。一只黄铜桶、一根柄上裂了口的骑鞭，还有一尊石膏圣徒像上的一条肢体，都摆在长桌上，而那张桌子要一直占到周五。真正让她恼火的是这些车本身，因为这个车队的主人按小时收费。胡桃木柜的贴面上添了一道新的划痕，她把这道划痕记在了清单上。父亲九点约了一位藏家见面，而她还有四十个条目要写。

九点钟，藏家到了，同来的还有一位从县城请来的律师，以及一位去年春天用电话买过三件拍品的银行家。他们放在内尔桌上的那份文件写明了整批藏品的产权移交，可签名的顺序排错了，律师也承认，在遗嘱执行人重新签字之前，这份文件在法律上是无效的。内尔早料到会有这种事，因为阿什菲尔德家为那个签名吵了两年，却没人想起来通知拍卖行。内尔没有抬高声音，承认了这个问题，转而提出做一次独立估价。银行家隔着眼镜上缘打量她，他的凝视在很长一段沉默里都带着敌意。

十一点开拍，出价之快是内尔整个季度没见过的，因为四部电话和前排的买家都在抢同一只橡木梳妆台。网络上的出价者比现场慢了整整一秒，于是每一次加价都变成书记员和屏幕之间的一场小争执。一位老先生煞有介事地折起图录站起身，可价格越过九百之后他又坐了回去。那年县里的生意很兴旺，这样的总价放在一个周二算是惊人的。第三十一号拍品没带标签就上来了，惊讶立刻变成混乱，三个人同时去翻同一层架子，随后的沉默尴尬得没人开口。内尔没忍住笑出声，房间里的气氛一下子变了。

第三十七号是那只胡桃木柜，就是带划痕的那只，拍卖师的解说词才念到第二句，律师又站了起来。他提议把这只柜子撤下来，因为它的文书跟着另一份遗产走错了地方，并请全场稍等片刻。内尔得同时协调两部电话、一份签好的表格和一个搬椅子的男孩，她把柜子跟后面那张素面桌子并成一组，这样就没有一件东西是没卖出去就离场的。真正的障碍不在钱，而在时间，她的坚持终于把律师磨了下来。对一个二十三岁的姑娘来说，这是个勇敢的决定，而这场拍卖的收尾几乎说得上安静。礼数要求她向每个人道两次谢。

这场拍卖进了本行的历史记录，成了本行记忆里最长的一个周二，内尔把总数写下来的时候，手已经不抖了。门口堆起一排木箱，齐腰高，直到车队最后一辆车顺着小巷开走。某种程度上她享受了这个下午，只是她不会跟父亲这么说。最让她不安的是那尊石膏圣徒像不见了，因为没人说得清买主是谁，司机把它侧着塞在油布底下拉走了。她在办公室吃了一片蛋糕，膝上摊着一本简装书，到六点时，和银行家那点争执已经开始弥合。一个行人在橱窗前停下脚步，她的一位同行招手让他进来。